A United Nations (UN) report from October 2024 reveals that organised crime syndicates are trafficking thousands of young men and women, luring them with fake job offers, often through social media, before coercing them into working at illegal scam compounds. Initially concentrated in Cambodia, these cyber slavery hubs have proliferated in Laos and Myanmar, where criminal networks exploit casino infrastructure, special economic zones and weak law enforcement to run their operations. According to the UN Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), financial losses from scams in Southeast Asia reached between $18 billion (Rs 1.6 lakh crore) and $37 billion (Rs 3.2 lakh crore) in 2023, much of it linked to organised crime in these three countries.

These operations follow a common playbook: trafficked individuals are forced to defraud people using advanced tools like AI-driven face-swapping and voice replication. The crisis spans a global scale—victims are recruited from Asia, Africa and South America, while the digital scams target populations in Asia, Europe, North America and Oceania.

INDIA'S BIG CONCERN

India, too, has found itself at the receiving end of this disturbing trend. According to data compiled by the Bureau of Immigration in the Union ministry of home affairs (MHA) last year, 29,466 Indians who had travelled on visitor visas to Thailand, Vietnam, Myanmar and Cambodia between January 2022 and May 2024 never returned. This was also the period during which the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), a division of the MHA, noted a significant rise in cybercrimes originating from Southeast Asia. Bihar's Economic Offences Wing (EOW) alone has identified 374 individuals who went missing after travelling to Southeast Asian countries on tourist visas. "Many of them have been coerced into working in cybercrime," an EOW officer told INDIA TODAY. The agency has meticulously verified this list and interviewed 69 men who managed to escape, often after their families were forced to pay ransom for their release.

RANJAN RAHI



"The mission was explicit: target Indian nationals and systematically swindle them. Refusal invited severe consequences"

–SHUBHAM KUMAR, *28-year-old Bihar native who was trapped at a scam compound in Cambodia*

On February 13, Kirti Vardhan Singh, minister of state for external affairs, acknowledged the issue in response to a Rajya Sabha query. Emphasising that the government "accords utmost priority to the safety, security and well-being of Indian nationals proceeding for employment abroad", he said that 3,111 unregistered domestic agents have been notified on the ministry's eMigrate portal—meant for overseas jobs—till December 2024. While the precise number of Indian victims remains unclear, the nation's diplomatic missions in Southeast Asia have successfully extracted at least 1,091 citizens from Cambodia, 770 from Laos and 497 from Myanmar in the past three years. In one of the latest transnational efforts in mid-February, 250 such people from 20 countries, including 23 from the Indian subcontinent, were brought to Thailand after they were released by an ethnic armed group in Myanmar.

Gautam Mukhopadhaya, former Indian ambassador to Myanmar, highlights how the insurgency-ridden situation in Myanmar has complicated India's efforts to rescue its stranded citizens. "The Myawaddy region is under the control of the Border Guarding Forces, comprising former insurgent groups," he says. "At some point, these groups were co-opted by the government and became an affiliate of the state apparatus. Today, the scam centres function under their patronage, which is why such operations have proliferated along the borders."



THE VICIOUS JOB CON

The line between perpetrators and victims of online frauds grows thin as criminal syndicates exploit vulnerable populations, turning job-seeking youths into cyber slaves

MODUS OPERANDI

How victims are tricked

Fake Job Offers
Ads on Facebook, Telegram and WhatsApp or local fraudulent agents promise high-paying IT or customer service jobs in Southeast Asia

Visa & Travel Arranged
Scammers offer flights, accommodation and work permits to make the job seem legitimate